

BELONG

The Discipleship Journey • Book 1



— *From Welcome to Witness* —
Thomas Perdana

THE DISCIPLESHIP JOURNEY • BOOK 1 OF 3

Beginner Track

By Thomas Perdana

BELONG: Your First Steps Into the Family of God

Part of *The Discipleship Journey: From Welcome to Witness*

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Your First Steps Into the Family of God

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FOREWORD: WHY THIS SERIES WAS WRITTEN

“Go ye therefore, and make disciples of all nations...” — Matthew 28:19

Every single year, millions of seeking men and women make the courageous decision to walk through the doors of a church or open their hearts to Jesus Christ. It is a moment filled with hope, tears, and holy anticipation.

Yet, tragically, far too many new believers find themselves lost within weeks.

They sit in a pew or log onto a livestream, hearing beautiful sermons about grace and faith, but quietly wondering:

- ✦ *“Where do I actually fit in this church family?”*
- ✦ *“How do I read this ancient Bible without getting confused?”*
- ✦ *“What are my unique spiritual gifts, and how does God want to use someone with my messy story?”*
- ✦ *“How do I share my faith with my family and friends without feeling awkward or pushy?”*

For decades, Christian literature has offered two extremes: either heavy, academic theological textbooks that intimidate everyday readers, or light, topical devotionals that leave believers spiritually hungry for deeper substance.

We wrote *The Discipleship Journey* series to bridge that gap.

This 3-book series was engineered to give you a clear, loving, step-by-step roadmap from the moment you take your first steps into God’s family to the day you stand as an empowered Kingdom Ambassador:

1. **Book 1: BELONG** — Answers your foundational questions about church family, essential doctrine, baptism, communion, and membership, taking you from a stranger on the outside to a cherished family member at the table.
2. **Book 2: GROW** — Establishes the 4 daily habits of mature believers (Word, Prayer, Giving, Community) and guides you through an interactive discovery of your unique **S.H.A.P.E.** (Spiritual Gifts, Heart, Abilities, Personality, and Experiences).
3. **Book 3: GO** — Arms you with a 3-part personal testimony workshop, conversational evangelism tools, relational network mapping (*Oikos*), and digital witness skills to change your world for Christ.

We wrote these books because we believe in **your chair at the table**. You were not saved by accident, and you are not called to wander in spiritual confusion. As you turn these pages, our prayer is that you

feel the warm embrace of God’s family and the thrilling call to live a life of eternal purpose. Scripture anchors are primary KJV with modern language clarity notes—accessible for all translation preferences.

Welcome to the journey. You belong here.

— **The Pastoral & Author Team**

CHAPTER 1: WELCOME HOME

“Now therefore ye are no more strangers and foreigners, but fellowcitizens with the saints, and of the household of God.” — Ephesians 2:19 (KJV)

The Empty Chair at the Table

Have you ever walked into a room full of people where everyone seemed to know each other, but you felt completely alone? You scan the room, clutching your coffee cup, asking yourself: *“Do I really belong here? Or am I just a guest who will be forgotten by Tuesday?”*

If you have ever carried that heavy isolation, hear these two words loud and clear: **Welcome home.**

You are not an accident. God has been orchestrating your steps long before you realized it. For over 47 years—since I surrendered my life to Jesus Christ as a 12-year-old boy in Indonesia—I have walked with the Good Shepherd. And in my weekly ministry as a jail chaplain behind the steel bars of Seminole County and Orange County Jail in Florida, I meet men whom the world has written off. They sit on concrete bunks wearing jumpsuit uniforms, feeling disqualified, dirty, and forgotten.

Yet, when we open the King James Version of the Holy Scriptures together, a holy miracle happens. The Spirit of God breaks through the cold walls and whispers to their hearts: *“You are not a convict; you are My child. There is a chair at My table with your name on it.”*

Jesus didn’t build a corporate institution; He built a **family**. In God’s household, there are no unwanted guests, no second-class citizens, and no temporary foster children. You belong here.

From Strangers to Household Members: A KJV Word Study

In Ephesians 2:19, the Apostle Paul writes to believers who felt like outsiders on the margins of society. Notice the profound spiritual upgrade God performs in your life the instant you trust in Christ:

1. **“No More Strangers” (Paroikos):** A *stranger* is someone living beside a community without holding rights or security. In Christ, your status as a spiritual outsider is permanently cancelled. You no longer wander near the edges of God’s blessing—you dwell in the center of His love.
2. **“No More Foreigners” (Xenos):** A *foreigner* is a traveler passing through a land, subject to alien taxes and exclusion. But Paul declares you are now **“fellowcitizens with the saints.”** You hold full, unalienable Kingdom citizenship with direct, 24/7 access to the Throne of Grace.

3. **“Of the Household of God” (*Oikeios tou Theou*):** This is the intimate climax of the verse. You are not merely a citizen of a kingdom; you are adopted into the **Father’s immediate family**. You share the family table, eat the family bread, and inherit the family glory.

“But as many as received him, to them gave he power to become the sons of God, even to them that believe on his name.” — John 1:12 (KJV)

Your Royal Identity: Prophet, Priest, and King in Christ

When God adopts you into His household, He doesn’t just grant you a seat; He clothes you with royal dignity and authority. Through Jesus Christ—the Chief Prophet, High Priest, and King of Kings—you now carry a three-fold spiritual calling:

- ✦ **The Prophetic Calling (Truth & Voice):** As a prophet in Christ, you are no longer deceived by the lies of the world or the accuser. You stand on the infallible Word of God (KJV), declaring His truth over your life, your family, and your generation.
- ✦ **The Priestly Calling (Grace & Intercession):** As a priest unto God (1 Peter 2:9), you have direct access to intercede for others, offer spiritual sacrifices of praise, and bring comfort, healing, and reconciliation to a broken world.
- ✦ **The Kingly Calling (Authority & Order):** As a royal heir (Romans 8:17), you walk in spiritual authority over darkness, bringing divine order, discipline, stewardship, and Kingdom multiplication into every environment you step into.

Belonging Comes Before Becoming

Worldly culture demands performance before acceptance: *“Earn your spot, prove your worth, fix your life, and then we might accept you.”*

In God’s family, the order is completely reversed: **Belonging comes before becoming.**

Jesus did not wait for Peter, James, and John to earn theological degrees before inviting them into His inner circle. He looked at rough, foul-mouthed fishermen and said, *“Follow Me”* (Matthew 4:19). As they walked with Him in daily community, His love transformed their character.

You do not clean yourself up *in order to come* to God; you come to God *in order to be made clean*. His grace accepts you as you are, but His love refuses to leave you as you are.

“Let’s Get Real”: Overcoming Doubts, Past Hurt, and Stigmas

“A bruised reed shall he not break, and smoking flax shall he not quench...” — Matthew 12:20 (KJV)

If you carry deep wounds from past church experiences, religious hypocrisy, or severe personal shame, hear this pastoral truth: human beings are imperfect, but Jesus Christ is flawless. Don't let a bad experience with the sheep keep you away from the Good Shepherd.

The church is not a museum for flawless saints; it is a **24/7 trauma hospital for sinners** being healed by grace. Whether you walked out of a boardroom or out of a prison cell, the blood of Jesus Christ cleanseth us from all sin (1 John 1:7).

Reflection & Deepening Questions

1. **Personal Identity:** How does Ephesians 2:19 redefine your spiritual status from a “stranger” to a “household member”?
2. **Prophet, Priest, King:** In what practical ways can you begin walking in your priestly role (interceding/praying for others) and your kingly role (bringing order and stewardship to your life) this week?
3. **Grace vs. Performance:** Why is it crucial to understand that *belonging comes before becoming* in your daily relationship with God?

Action Step & Commissioning Prayer

- ✦ **Practical Action Step:** This week, make a conscious commitment to step out of the shadows. Introduce yourself to 3 people at church, tell your pastor or small group leader that you are ready to grow, and write down 3 people in your life who need your prayers.
- ✦ **Commissioning Prayer:**

“Heavenly Father, thank You for loving me when I was far away and bringing me home into Your household. I declare by faith that I am no longer a stranger or a foreigner, but a fellowcitizen and a beloved child of God. Clothe me in my royal identity as a prophet, priest, and king in Christ. Use my life to bring glory to Your Name. In Jesus’ precious Name, Amen.”

CHAPTER 2: WHAT WE BELIEVE

“Hold fast the form of sound words, which thou hast heard of me, in faith and love which is in Christ Jesus.” — 2 Timothy 1:13 (KJV)

The Compass in a Storm

Imagine a ship captain attempting to navigate a roaring ocean in a pitch-black storm without a compass, radar, or lighthouse. The winds howl, waves crash over the deck, and every direction looks identical. Without a fixed reference point, that vessel will inevitably drift into shallow reefs and shatter against the rocks.

In our modern culture, millions of souls are drifting in a fog of moral relativism, spiritual confusion, and constantly shifting opinions. Culture tells you: *“Truth is whatever you feel it to be.”* But feelings change like the morning wind.

Doctrine is not cold, dry academic theory. **Doctrine is your spiritual compass.** It is the unshakeable, God-given truth upon which you can anchor your soul and lean the entire weight of your life. When everything around you is shaking, knowing *what you believe* and *why you believe* it keeps you standing tall as a Kingdom soldier.

The Anchor of “Sound Words” (Hugai non Logon)

In 2 Timothy 1:13, the Apostle Paul instructs his young disciple Timothy: *“Hold fast the form of sound words...”*

The Greek word Paul uses for *sound* is **hugai non** (from which we get our modern word *hygiene*). It means healthy, whole, wholesome, and life-giving.

False doctrine is spiritual poison—it infects the mind with fear, pride, and legalism. But **sound doctrine is spiritual hygiene.** It purifies your thoughts, heals past trauma, builds immune strength against temptation, and restores peace to your heart.

For many years as Vice President of our local Gideons International chapter in North Seminole County, Florida, I have had the sacred privilege of distributing God’s Holy Word into schools, hotel rooms, military bases, and prison cells. I have watched hardened men in jumpsuit uniforms pick up a simple Testament, read the pure KJV text, and experience an instant spiritual cleansing. The Word of God possesses intrinsic power. When you hold fast to sound words, the truth doesn’t just inform your intellect—it transforms your destiny!

The Four Essential Pillars of Our Faith

As a new believer walking in your royal identity as a prophet, priest, and king, you must lay four unshakeable granite pillars beneath your spiritual foundation:

Pillar 1: The Inspired Word of God (*Sola Scriptura*)

“All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: That the man of God may be perfect, thoroughly furnished unto all good works.” — 2 Timothy 3:16-17 (KJV)

The Bible is not a collection of human fables; it is the supernaturally breathed-out (*theopneustos*) Word of the Almighty. Notice the four-fold work of Scripture:

- ✦ **Doctrine:** Tells you what is *right*.
- ✦ **Reproof:** Shows you what is *not right*.
- ✦ **Correction:** Teaches you how to *get right*.
- ✦ **Instruction in Righteousness:** Shows you how to *stay right*.

Pillar 2: The Triune God (The Holy Trinity)

“For there are three that bear record in heaven, the Father, the Word, and the Holy Ghost: and these three are one.” — 1 John 5:7 (KJV)

We worship One true God who eternally exists in three distinct Persons: God the Father (our loving Creator), God the Son (Jesus Christ, our Redeemer), and God the Holy Spirit (our Indwelling Comforter and Guide). They are co-equal, co-eternal, and perfectly united in love and purpose.

Pillar 3: The Person & Work of Jesus Christ

“For I delivered unto you first of all that which I also received, how that Christ died for our sins according to the scriptures; And that he was buried, and that he rose again the third day according to the scriptures.” — 1 Corinthians 15:3-4 (KJV)

Jesus Christ is not merely a moral teacher or historical prophet. He is the eternal Son of God, virgin-born, sinless in life, crucified as our substitutionary sacrifice, and physically resurrected from the dead on the third day. He ascended to Heaven and is coming again in power and glory!

Pillar 4: Salvation by Grace Through Faith

“For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: Not of works, lest any man should boast.” — Ephesians 2:8-9 (KJV)

Salvation cannot be bought, earned, or inherited by religious rituals or good deeds. It is the free, unmerited gift of God, purchased by the precious blood of Jesus Christ and received through faith alone. Works are not the *root* of salvation; they are the joyous *fruit* of a transformed heart!

“Let’s Get Real”: Do I Have to Understand Everything to Be Saved?

A question many new believers secretly ask is: *“What if I can’t understand all this theology? Does God still accept me?”*

Consider an airplane. You do not need to understand aerospace engineering, fluid dynamics, or jet engine mechanics to board a flight to California. You simply trust the pilot, step into the cabin, and sit down.

In the same way, faith does not require total comprehension of every theological mystery before you can trust God. You do not have to master Greek, Hebrew, or systematic theology to belong in God’s household.

Faith is not comprehending God with your brain; it is **yielding your heart to Jesus Christ**. As you walk with Him day by day, the Holy Spirit will gradually open the eyes of your understanding (Ephesians 1:18).

“That we henceforth be no more children, tossed to and fro, and carried about with every wind of doctrine, by the sleight of men, and cunning craftiness...” — Ephesians 4:14 (KJV)

Reflection & Deepening Questions

1. **The Spiritual Compass:** How does anchoring your life in sound biblical doctrine protect you from being “tossed to and fro” by cultural opinions?
2. **The 4-Fold Work of Scripture:** Look at 2 Timothy 3:16. Can you recall a moment when God’s Word gave you *reproof* (showed what wasn’t right) or *correction* (showed how to get right)?
3. **Grace vs. Works:** Why is it liberating to know that your salvation rests entirely on Christ’s completed work on the cross rather than your own performance?

Action Step & Commissioning Prayer

- ✦ **Practical Action Step:** Write **2 Timothy 1:13** on an index card or save it as your phone wallpaper. Recite it aloud three times daily this week as a prophetic declaration of your commitment to hold fast to sound words.
- ✦ **Commissioning Prayer:**

“Lord God of Truth, thank You for giving me the unshakeable rock of Your Holy Word. I reject the lies and confusion of this world and choose to build my life upon the solid foundation of sound doctrine. Protect my mind, strengthen my faith, and teach me to walk boldly as a prophet, priest, and king in Your Kingdom. In the victorious Name of Jesus Christ, Amen.”

CHAPTER 3: HOW WE OPERATE

“Let all things be done decently and in order.” — 1 Corinthians 14:40 (KJV)

The Symphony and the Score

Have you ever sat in a concert hall right before a performance begins? The musicians tune their instruments—violins squeak, trumpets blare, drums rumble, and flutes screech. Taken individually, it is a wall of chaotic noise. But the moment the conductor steps onto the podium, raises his baton, and taps the music stand, silence falls. When he motions, every instrument plays in perfect alignment with the written score. What was once ear-splitting noise becomes a breathtaking, glorious symphony!

In spiritual life, **God is not the author of confusion, but of peace** (1 Corinthians 14:33).

Structure is not the enemy of the Holy Spirit; structure is the divine vessel through which the Holy Spirit flows without hindrance. As a jail chaplain ministering weekly in Seminole County and Orange County Jail, I witness daily that the line between order and chaos is a matter of life and death. Behind correctional walls, strict routine, clear authority, and structured protocols prevent anarchy and protect human life.

In the local church—the Household of God—biblical order creates a safe, healthy environment where new believers can flourish, heal from past trauma, and grow into maturity without fear of spiritual chaos or manipulation.

Decently and In Order: A KJV Word Study

In 1 Corinthians 14:40, the Apostle Paul issues a royal command for Kingdom governance: *“Let all things be done decently and in order.”*

Look closely at those two inspired words:

1. **“Decently”** (*Euschemónōs*): This Greek word means with noble dignity, spiritual beauty, decorum, and honor. Gospel ministry should never be sloppy, deceitful, or careless. It should reflect the royal majesty of our King!
2. **“In Order”** (*Taxis*): This is a military term referring to soldiers lined up in precise rank and formation. It means everyone knows their position, respects the chain of command, covers their neighbor’s flank, and marches together toward victory.

When a church operates *decently and in order*, the spiritual atmosphere is charged with peace, power, and divine protection.

Biblical Leadership Roles: The Kingdom Structure

The New Testament provides a clear, three-part blueprint for how God’s family is organized so that every member is cared for, protected, and empowered:

A. Pastors / Elders / Overseers (Episkopos & Poimen)

“Obey them that have the rule over you, and submit yourselves: for they watch for your souls, as they that must give account...” — Hebrews 13:17 (KJV)

Pastors and elders are God’s under-shepherds. Their primary calling is to preach the pure Word of God, guard the flock against spiritual wolves (Acts 20:28-29), pray for the sick (James 5:14), and give spiritual direction. They do not rule as tyrants, but lead as servant-shepherds who will one day give an accounting before Jesus Christ.

B. Deacons (Diakonos — Servant Leaders)

“For they that have used the office of a deacon well purchase to themselves a good degree, and great boldness in the faith...” — 1 Timothy 3:13 (KJV)

The office of deacon was created in Acts 6:1-7 to handle physical care, facility operations, financial administration, and benevolent outreach. Deacons shield the pastors from operational distractions so pastors can dedicate themselves to prayer and the ministry of the Word.

C. The Congregation (Active Ministry Partners)

“And he gave some, apostles; and some, prophets; and some, evangelists; and some, pastors and teachers; For the perfecting of the saints, for the work of the ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ.” — Ephesians 4:11-12 (KJV)

Here is the revolutionary biblical truth: **Pastors are not hired performers; they are athletic coaches!** Their job is to “perfect” (equip and train) *you*—the saints—so that *you* can do the work of the ministry. In God’s household, there are no passive bench-warmers. You walk in your royal identity as a prophet, priest, and king, actively serving with your God-given gifts!

“Let’s Get Real”: Why Structure Protects You

Many people who have been wounded by religious cults or authoritarian leaders ask: *“Isn’t church hierarchy dangerous? What if leaders abuse their power?”*

That is a valid concern. But biblical structure is actually your **strongest defense against abuse**:

- ✦ **Plurality of Elders:** The New Testament pattern is never a single dictator, but a team of qualified elders who keep each other accountable (Proverbs 11:14).
- ✦ **Strict Moral Qualifications:** 1 Timothy 3 and Titus 1 require leaders to be blameless, temperate, non-violent, not greedy for money, and respected in their homes.
- ✦ **Financial Transparency:** Healthy churches maintain open books, independent financial oversight, and ethical accounting so that Kingdom resources are handled with absolute integrity.

Structure does not restrict your freedom; **godly structure protects your freedom** so you can grow without fear.

Reflection & Deepening Questions

1. **Military Order (*Taxis*):** Why is alignment and military-style teamwork (*taxis*) essential for a local church to overcome spiritual opposition in its community?
2. **Equipping the Saints:** According to Ephesians 4:11-12, what is the main responsibility of pastors toward you as a new believer?
3. **Submitting to Shepherds:** How does praying regularly for your pastors and elders strengthen your own spiritual immunity and peace?

Action Step & Commissioning Prayer

- ✦ **Practical Action Step:** Write down the names of your senior pastor, elders, and ministry team leaders. Commit to interceding for them daily this week—praying for their protection, wisdom, family strength, and spiritual boldness.
- ✦ **Commissioning Prayer:**

“Lord Jesus Christ, You are the Supreme Head of the Church and the Chief Shepherd of my soul. I thank You for setting godly order, leadership, and protection in Your house. Grant our pastors and leaders divine wisdom, courage, and holiness. Teach me to take my place in the rank with joy, serving with my gifts as a prophet, priest, and king to build up Your Kingdom. In Jesus’ Name, Amen.”

CHAPTER 4: THE BIBLE: YOUR LIFE MANUAL

“Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, and a light unto my path.” — Psalm 119:105 (KJV)

The Unopened Instruction Manual

Suppose you bought a brand-new, high-performance vehicle equipped with an advanced navigation system, lane-assist, and satellite guidance. But instead of reading the owner’s manual or turning on the GPS, you drove blindfolded into a dark mountain range at midnight. How far would you travel before crashing into a ditch?

Yet, millions of people attempt to navigate the complex terrain of marriage, finances, mental health, career, and eternity completely blindfolded! They rely on worldly pop psychology, social media trends, or volatile emotions, wondering why their lives are plagued by anxiety and wreckage.

God did not leave you to fumble in the dark. He gave you 66 inspired books bound into one Holy Bible—the ultimate owner’s manual for human life!

When David writes in Psalm 119:105 that God’s Word is a **lamp unto my feet** and a **light unto my path**, he describes two distinct types of spiritual illumination:

- ✦ **A Lamp Unto My Feet:** A small oil lamp held close to the ground illuminates your very next step *today*. It guides your immediate decisions: what to say, how to react, and where to place your feet right now.
- ✦ **A Light Unto My Path:** A bright beacon shining into the distance, illuminating your long-term Kingdom trajectory, your ultimate purpose, and your eternal destiny.

The Living Power of the KJV Scriptures

“For the word of God is quick, and powerful, and sharper than any twoedged sword, piercing even to the dividing asunder of soul and spirit, and of the joints and marrow, and is a discerner of the thoughts and intents of the heart.” — Hebrews 4:12 (KJV)

Look at how the King James Version describes the Word of God:

1. **“Quick”**: In Old English, *quick* means **living** or **alive**! Other books contain dead ink on paper; the Bible is a living organism inhabited by the Holy Spirit. When you read the Bible, the Bible reads you!
2. **“Powerful” (Energies)**: From which we get our word *energy*. The Word carries active, supernatural energy that breaks addiction, heals broken minds, and dispels demonic darkness.
3. **“Sharper Than Any Twoedged Sword”**: In your royal identity as a king and priest, Scripture is your offensive weapon—the **Sword of the Spirit** (Ephesians 6:17). You do not fight spiritual battles with human arguments; you defeat the enemy by declaring *“It is written!”* just as Jesus did in the wilderness (Matthew 4:4).

As Vice President of Gideons International in North Seminole County, Florida, I have handed out thousands of Scriptures. I remember a testimony of a hopeless man sitting in a hotel room, ready to end his life. He opened the nightstand drawer, pulled out a Gideon KJV New Testament, and turned to John 3:16. The living power of the Word pierced his heart, shattered his depression, and saved his life that very night.

In my jail ministry at Seminole County and Orange County Jails, I watch men serving long sentences pick up the Bible. Though their bodies are confined behind steel bars, their souls are liberated by the truth!

Why Can You Trust the Bible? Four Unshakeable Pillars

When skeptics ask why you lean your life on Scripture, you can stand with prophetic confidence on four historical pillars:

1. **Supernatural Internal Unity**: Written over 1,500 years across 3 continents (Asia, Africa, Europe) in 3 languages (Hebrew, Aramaic, Greek) by 40 different authors (kings, fishermen, scholars, military commanders, shepherds)—yet telling **one seamless, non-contradictory story of redemption through Jesus Christ!**
2. **Fulfilled Prophecy**: Over 300 precise Old Testament prophecies concerning Christ’s birthplace (Micah 5:2), virgin birth (Isaiah 7:14), crucifixion details (Psalm 22), and resurrection (Psalm 16:10) were fulfilled to the exact letter hundreds of years later.
3. **Archaeological Confirmation**: Tens of thousands of archaeological digs across the Middle East consistently verify biblical cities, kings, battles, and historical details without a single contradiction.
4. **Transformed Lives**: For 2,000 years, the Bible has transformed drug addicts into pastors, tyrants into saints, and broken families into pillars of community.

Practical Discipleship Tool: The S.O.A.P. Study Method

How do you read the Bible every day so that it transforms your life? Use this simple, battle-tested 4-step method in your daily quiet time notebook:

- ✦ **S — Scripture**: Open your KJV Bible, read a chapter, and write down 1 or 2 key verses that grab your heart.
- ✦ **O — Observation**: Ask: *“What is God saying in this text? What key words stand out? What does it reveal about God’s character or human nature?”*

- ✦ **A — Application:** Apply it directly to your life as a prophet, priest, and king. Ask: *“How does this truth command my actions today? What sin must I confess? What promise must I claim?”*
- ✦ **P — Prayer:** Write a 2-sentence prayer asking the Holy Spirit to help you obey what you just read.

“Let’s Get Real”: How Do I Overcome Distractions & Build a Daily Habit?

Many new believers say: *“I start reading, but my mind wanders, or I get stuck in difficult chapters like Leviticus!”*

Here are three pastoral rules to build an unshakeable habit:

- ✦ **Set a Fixed Time & Spot:** Give God the first 15 minutes of your day before checking your smartphone or news.
- ✦ **Start in the Gospels:** Begin your journey in the **Book of John**. Read one chapter a day. John presents Jesus in all His divine majesty and grace.
- ✦ **Read for Transformation, Not Speed:** It is far better to read 5 verses deeply with a prayerful heart than to skim 5 chapters quickly without remembering anything.

“This book of the law shall not depart out of thy mouth; but thou shalt meditate therein day and night, that thou mayest observe to do according to all that is written therein: for then thou shalt make thy way prosperous, and then thou shalt have good success.” — Joshua 1:8 (KJV)

Reflection & Deepening Questions

1. **Lamp & Light:** What is the difference between God’s Word being a *lamp unto your feet* (daily decisions) and a *light unto your path* (long-term destiny)?
2. **The Sword of the Spirit:** How can you use KJV Scripture as a weapon when tempted by fear, doubt, or temptation this week?
3. **S.O.A.P. Method:** Why is writing down your daily observations and applications more effective than just passive reading?

Action Step & Commissioning Prayer

- ✦ **Practical Action Step:** Commit to a **7-Day S.O.A.P. Challenge**. Pick up a notebook, open to the **Book of John (Chapters 1 to 7)**, and spend 15 minutes each morning completing one S.O.A.P. entry per day.
- ✦ **Commissioning Prayer:**

“Father in Heaven, thank You for giving me the priceless treasure of Your Holy Word. Open my eyes that I may behold wondrous things out of Your law. Quicken my heart by Your truth, sharpen my sword for

spiritual victory, and let Your Word be a lamp unto my feet and a light unto my path every single day. In Jesus' mighty Name, Amen."

CHAPTER 5: SALVATION & GRACE: THE GREATEST GIFT

“For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God: Not of works, lest any man should boast.” — Ephesians 2:8-9 (KJV)

The Unpayable Debt and the Divine Pardon

Imagine standing inside a solemn courtroom before an infinitely holy Judge. The evidence against you is stacked high: every sinful thought, selfish deed, broken promise, and rebellious act recorded in detail. The verdict is read: **Guilty**. The sentence is absolute: death and eternal separation from God (Romans 6:23). You have no money to pay the bail, no legal defense to offer, and no good deeds to balance the scales.

Suddenly, the Judge steps down from his lofty bench, removes his judicial robes, and steps to your side. He takes your place in the executioner’s chair, pays your debt in full with His own life’s blood, and hands you a signed, sealed pardon stamped: **PAID IN FULL!**

That is the Gospel of Jesus Christ.

In human religion, we often confuse three critical terms:

- ✦ **Justice:** Getting the exact punishment you deserve.
- ✦ **Mercy:** NOT getting the punishment you deserve.
- ✦ **Grace:** Getting the glorious, royal inheritance and favor that you could *never* earn or deserve!

The Great Spiritual Upgrade: Religion vs. Grace

As a jail chaplain ministering behind correctional bars in Seminole County and Orange County Jail, I meet many incarcerated men who live under the crushing weight of legal probation. On earthly probation, one minor infraction or failed test sends you straight back to a dark cell. Many bring that same paranoid “probation mindset” into their relationship with God, living in constant terror that one mistake will cause God to abandon them.

I love taking those men to **Colossians 2:14** in the King James Version:

“Blotting out the handwriting of ordinances that was against us, which was contrary to us, and took it out of the way, nailing it to his cross.” — Colossians 2:14 (KJV)

In ancient times, when a criminal served his sentence or had his debt paid, the magistrate took the legal record of charges (*the handwriting of ordinances*) and drove a nail through it, writing the word **TETELESTAI** across the top— *“Paid in Full!”*

Religion says: **“DO”** (work harder, perform better, clean yourself up).

The Gospel of Grace says: **“DONE”** (Jesus paid it all at Calvary!).

The Four-Act Metanarrative of the Gospel Story

To stand tall in your royal identity as a prophet, priest, and king, you must master the grand 4-Act Story of Scripture:

Act 1: Creation (God’s Perfect Design)

“And God saw every thing that he had made, and, behold, it was very good...” — Genesis 1:31 (KJV)

God created the universe in absolute perfection, harmony, and beauty. Man was created in the image of God to reign as a royal steward, enjoying unbroken fellowship with his Creator.

Act 2: Fall (Human Sin & Ruin)

“For all have sinned, and come short of the glory of God...” — Romans 3:23 (KJV)

Adam’s rebellion introduced sin, spiritual death, sickness, and curse into the world (Romans 5:12). Sin fractured our relationship with God, poisoned our human nature, and declared spiritual bankruptcy over every human soul.

Act 3: Redemption (The Cross & Resurrection)

“Who his own self bare our sins in his own body on the tree, that we, being dead to sins, should live unto righteousness: by whose stripes ye were healed.” — 1 Peter 2:24 (KJV)

God did not abandon us to ruin. He sent His only begotten Son, Jesus Christ, to live the sinless life we could not live and die the sacrificial death we deserved to die. On the cross, Jesus cried out *“It is finished!”* (John 19:30), breaking the power of sin, hell, and the grave forever!

Act 4: Restoration (New Creation & Royalty)

“Therefore if any man be in Christ, he is a new creature: old things are passed away; behold, all things are become new.” — 2 Corinthians 5:17 (KJV)

The moment you trust in Christ, you are spiritually resurrected! You are no longer defined by your past sins, criminal records, or family failures. You are declared “**the righteousness of God in him**” (2 Corinthians 5:21) and restored to your royal purpose!

“Let’s Get Real”: What If I Still Slip Up?

A deep concern every new believer faces is: *“What happens when I mess up or stumble into sin after being saved? Did I lose my salvation?”*

Understand the vital difference between a **relationship** and **fellowship**:

- ✦ Your **relationship** as a child of God is fixed by the blood of Christ. When my children make mistakes, they don’t cease to be my children; they are still my flesh and blood.
- ✦ Your **fellowship** (daily joy and closeness) can be temporarily strained by unconfessed sin.

If you slip up, do not run *away* from God in shame; run *to* God in repentance!

“If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.” — 1 John 1:9 (KJV)

Notice the illustration: When a pig slips into the mud, it wallows in it because mud is its nature. But when a sheep stumbles into the mud, it bleats in distress until the Shepherd pulls it out and washes its wool clean! As a child of God, you are a sheep—sin is no longer your nature.

Reflection & Deepening Questions

1. **Justice, Mercy, Grace:** How does understanding the difference between Justice (getting punishment), Mercy (sparing punishment), and Grace (getting royal favor) change your heart toward God?
2. **Colossians 2:14:** What does it mean to you personally that your entire record of past sins was nailed to the cross and stamped “Paid in Full”?
3. **New Identity:** How does 2 Corinthians 5:17 help you silence the voice of the accuser when he tries to bring up your past mistakes?

Action Step & Commissioning Prayer

✦ **Practical Action Step:** Start a **7-Day Grace Gratitude Journal**. Every evening before sleep, write down 3 specific blessings, answers to prayer, or instances of God’s unmerited favor you experienced during the day.

✦ **Commissioning Prayer:**

“Lord Jesus Christ, my Redeemer and King, I stand in awe of Your matchless grace. Thank You for taking my place on the cross, nailing my legal debt to the tree, and clothing me in Your perfect righteousness. I declare that I am a new creation in Christ—old things are passed away, and all things are become new! Use my life to proclaim Your mercy to a lost world. In Your holy Name, Amen.”

CHAPTER 6: BAPTISM & COMMUNION: SACRED SYMBOLS OF SALVATION

“Therefore we are buried with him by baptism into death: that like as Christ was raised up from the dead by the glory of the Father, even so we also should walk in newness of life.” — Romans 6:4 (KJV)

The Royal Uniform and the Covenant Table

When a soldier enlists in a military branch, his heart is committed to his country. But the day he puts on the official military uniform in front of his battalion, his private commitment becomes a public declaration. Everyone who sees him knows instantly: *“This soldier belongs to the Sovereign.”*

In the Household of God, King Jesus instituted two sacred ordinances—**Water Baptism** and **The Lord’s Supper (Communion)**.

These are not empty religious rituals or mechanical sacraments that save your soul. Salvation is by grace through faith alone (Ephesians 2:8-9). Rather, Baptism and Communion are the two sacred **wedding rings** of our faith—outward, visible symbols of an inward, invisible spiritual covenant!

A wedding ring does not make you married; a couple is united by their vows in heart and law. But wearing that gold band announces to the entire world: *“I am taken. I belong to another, and I am not ashamed of my covenant.”*

Believer’s Water Baptism: Your Public Coronation

“Buried with him in baptism, wherein also ye are risen with him through the faith of the operation of God, who hath raised him from the dead.” — Colossians 2:12 (KJV)

The Greek word used in the New Testament for baptism is **baptizo**, which literally means to submerge, immerse, or plunge beneath water. This is why biblical baptism is performed by full immersion:

1. **Going Under the Water:** Symbolizes your **death and burial** with Jesus Christ. Your old life, past sins, criminal records, addictions, and worldly identity are buried in a watery grave.

2. **Coming Up Out of the Water:** Symbolizes your **resurrection** to walk in “newness of life” by the power of the Holy Spirit. You rise as a royal son or daughter of the King!

As a jail chaplain ministering in Seminole County and Orange County Jail, some of the most holy moments of my life have occurred watching incarcerated men step into the baptismal water. Inside a correctional facility, inmate culture is dominated by gang alliances and street codes. When a prisoner steps forward to be baptized in front of fellow inmates, he is making a radical, fearless declaration: *“I am cutting my ties with the darkness. I am stepping out of the shadows. I pledge my public allegiance to King Jesus!”*

If you have surrendered your life to Christ, water baptism is your non-negotiable next step of obedience (Matthew 28:19, Acts 2:41).

The Lord’s Supper (Communion): Re-Anchoring at the Family Table

“For as often as ye eat this bread, and drink this cup, ye do shew the Lord’s death till he come.” — 1 Corinthians 11:26 (KJV)

The second ordinance given by Christ is **Communion** (The Lord’s Supper). In 1 Corinthians 11:23-29, the Apostle Paul reveals three holy dimensions of the Communion table:

A. Looking Back (Remembrance)

- ✦ **The Broken Bread:** Represents the physical body of Jesus Christ, torn, beaten, and bruised for our transgressions (Isaiah 53:5).
- ✦ **The Cup:** Represents the precious blood of the New Testament, poured out at Calvary to wash away our sins (Matthew 26:28).

B. Looking Within (Self-Examination)

“But let a man examine himself, and so let him eat of that bread, and drink of that cup.” — 1 Corinthians 11:28 (KJV)

Before partaking of the elements, we pause in priestly quietness to inspect our hearts. We confess any known sin, lay down bitterness, and make peace with our brothers and sisters in Christ.

C. Looking Ahead (Expectation)

Notice the royal phrase: **“till he come.”** Communion is not a funeral wake; it is a victory celebration! Every time we hold the bread and cup, we are reminded that King Jesus is returning in glory to gather His bride for the eternal Marriage Supper of the Lamb (Revelation 19:9).

“Let’s Get Real”: What If I’m Afraid of Public Water or Feel Unworthy for Communion?

Two common anxieties hold new believers back:

1. “I have stage fright or fear of being under water!”

Remember that your church family is not a panel of critical judges; we are your brothers and sisters cheering you on! Your pastor will gently hold you, lower you smoothly, and bring you right back up. It is a moment of pure joy and celebration.

1. “I feel unworthy to take Communion. What if I’m not good enough?”

Hear this liberating truth: **Nobody takes Communion because they are worthy in themselves!** If we had to be perfect to come to the Lord’s table, the table would be completely empty. We come to Communion precisely because we are needy sinners covered by the worthiness of Jesus Christ.

Reflection & Deepening Questions

1. **Public Allegiance:** Why is public water baptism such a vital line of demarcation between your old worldly life and your new identity in Christ?
2. **The Three Directions of Communion:** How does looking *Back* to the Cross, looking *Within* your heart, and looking *Ahead* to Christ’s return keep your faith alive and vibrant?
3. **The Wedding Ring Analogy:** Why is it dangerous to rely on baptism to save you, but equally dangerous to disobey Christ by refusing to be baptized?

Action Step & Commissioning Prayer

✦ **Practical Action Step:** If you have trusted Jesus as your Lord but have never been baptized by immersion, contact your pastor or church leader today and say: *“I am ready to be baptized!”* If you are already baptized, prepare your heart for the next Communion service by spending 10 minutes in quiet self-examination and thanksgiving.

✦ **Commissioning Prayer:**

“Lord Jesus, thank You for instituting these holy ordinances to anchor my soul. I am not ashamed of the Gospel of Christ! Give me boldness to declare my public allegiance through water baptism, and fill my heart with holy awe every time I gather at Your Communion table. I am Yours, bought by Your blood and raised in Your power. In Jesus’ glorious Name, Amen.”

CHAPTER 7: HOW WE WORSHIP

“God is a Spirit: and they that worship him must worship him in spirit and in truth.” — John 4:24 (KJV)

The Audience of One

Have you ever attended a concert or sporting event where thousands of fans cheered, clapped, and sang along at the top of their lungs? In a stadium, the performers or athletes are on stage, and the crowd in the seats is the audience evaluating the performance.

Tragically, many people bring that same consumer mentality into church. They sit in a pew, cross their arms, and evaluate the Sunday service: *“The music was too loud,” “The band wasn’t polished,”* or *“The sermon didn’t entertain me.”*

In biblical Christianity, the arrangement is completely reversed:

- ♦ **The Worship Team and Pastors** are not performers; they are humble prompters.
- ♦ **The Congregation** is not the audience; you are the choir on the field!
- ♦ **God Himself** is the sole **Audience of One**!

Worship is not a show designed to entertain human consumers; worship is the sacred, royal offering of a redeemed soul poured out at the feet of the King of Kings!

In Spirit and In Truth: A KJV Exegesis

In John 4:23-24, Jesus reveals a shocking truth to the Samaritan woman at Jacob’s well: *“the Father seeketh such to worship him.”* Think about that! God is not seeking your money, your eloquence, or your religious achievements—He is seeking **true worshippers**.

Jesus reveals two non-negotiable pillars of true worship:

1. **Worship in Spirit (*Pneuma*)**: Wholehearted, passion-filled, Holy Spirit-energized devotion. God despises cold, mechanical, half-hearted religious routine (Isaiah 29:13). True worship involves your heart, mind, emotions, and physical expression—raising hands (Psalm 134:2), shouting praise (Psalm 47:1), and bowing in reverence (Psalm 95:6).
2. **Worship in Truth (*Aletheia*)**: Anchored in the pure, sound doctrine of the King James Scriptures. Emotional intensity without biblical truth is dangerous fanaticism; biblical truth without emotional warmth is dry intellectualism. True worship unites burning spiritual passion with rock-solid Scriptural truth!

As a jail chaplain in Seminole County and Orange County Jail, I have witnessed some of the most raw, powerful worship on earth. Inside a stark pod with concrete walls and no stage lights, haze machines, or professional guitars, incarcerated men lift their hands to Heaven. Tears stream down their faces as they sing *Amazing Grace* from the depths of their souls. In those moments, the Holy Spirit inhabits their praises (Psalm 22:3), and a cold jail cell transforms into the very Gate of Heaven!

24/7 Lifestyle Worship: The Living Sacrifice

“I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that ye present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable unto God, which is your reasonable service.” — Romans 12:1 (KJV)

Here is the royal secret: **Worship is not a 20-minute musical segment on Sunday morning; worship is a 24/7 lifestyle!**

In the Old Testament, a priest brought a slain animal to the altar. But under the New Covenant, as a priest unto God (1 Peter 2:9), you bring **yourself** to the altar as a *living sacrifice*.

What does 24/7 lifestyle worship look like in daily life?

- ✦ **At Work:** Doing your job with excellence and integrity as unto the Lord (Colossians 3:23) is worship!
- ✦ **In Finances:** Honoring God with your first-fruits tithes and generous offerings (Proverbs 3:9) is worship!
- ✦ **In Suffering:** Offering a “*sacrifice of praise*” (Hebrews 13:15) when your heart is breaking and tears are flowing is the sweetest fragrance to the Father’s heart.

“Let’s Get Real”: What If I Don’t Feel Emotional or Am Not Musical?

Two common hurdles hold new believers back in worship:

1. **“I am not a good singer, and I don’t want people hearing my voice!”**

Psalm 100:1 does not say “*Make a professional musical recording unto the Lord.*” It says: “**Make a joyful noise unto the LORD, all ye lands!**” God does not evaluate the vocal pitch of your voice; He evaluates the purity and posture of your heart. To God’s ears, the sincere praise of a tone-deaf believer is a glorious masterpiece!

1. **“What if I don’t feel happy or emotional on Sunday morning?”**

Worship is an act of the **will**, not a feeling of the emotions. When you praise God despite feeling tired, discouraged, or under spiritual attack, your worship becomes a powerful spiritual weapon that breaks demonic strongholds—just as Paul and Silas sang praises in the Philippian dungeon at midnight until the prison doors flew open (Acts 16:25-26)!

Reflection & Deepening Questions

1. **The Audience of One:** How does remembering that *God is the only Audience* in church change the way you prepare for and participate in Sunday worship?
2. **Spirit & Truth:** Is your personal worship leaning more toward cold routine or emotionalism without Scripture? How can you balance both this week?
3. **The Sacrifice of Praise:** Why is praising God during a difficult trial or painful heartbreak often the most powerful form of worship you can offer?

Action Step & Commissioning Prayer

✦ **Practical Action Step:** Implement a **Saturday Night Worship Discipline**. Prepare your clothes, heart, and Bible on Saturday evening. Turn off late-night distractions, go to sleep early, and arrive at church 10 minutes before the service starts to quiet your soul before the Audience of One.

✦ **Commissioning Prayer:**

“Almighty God, Creator of Heaven and Earth, You alone are worthy of all honor, glory, and praise! I present my life to You today as a living sacrifice. Tune my heart to sing Your grace not only with my lips on Sunday, but with my daily actions, work, and words all week long. Let my life be a continuous incense of praise before Your Throne. In the royal Name of Jesus Christ, Amen.”

CHAPTER 8: YOUR QUESTIONS, ANSWERED (FAQ)

“If any of you lack wisdom, let him ask of God, that giveth to all men liberally, and upbraideth not; and it shall be given him.” — James 1:5 (KJV)

The Seeking Mind and the Welcoming Father

Have you ever held back a burning question in a classroom or workplace because you were terrified of sounding foolish? You swallowed your confusion, stayed quiet, and walked away still bewildered.

Many new believers bring that same anxiety into their relationship with God. They secretly wonder: *“Is it a sin for me to have doubts? Will God be angry if I ask hard questions about suffering, unanswered prayers, or old temptations?”*

Hear the tender, reassuring voice of your Heavenly Father in **James 1:5**. Notice two magnificent words:

1. **“Giveth... Liberally”**: God does not ration His wisdom out with a dropper; He pours it out generously over an open heart!
2. **“Upbraideth Not”**: In KJV English, *upbraideth not* means **He does not scold, mock, or lecture you** for asking! God welcomes your seeking mind.

Through Isaiah, the Lord invites us: *“Come now, and let us reason together, saith the LORD”* (Isaiah 1:18). In your royal identity as a prophet, priest, and king, you do not shut off your brain when you follow Jesus—you anchor your intellect in the rock-solid truth of God’s Word!

The Top 5 Hard Questions Answered from the KJV

As a jail chaplain behind the steel bars of Seminole County and Orange County Jail, and as Vice President of Gideons International in North Seminole County, Florida, I have sat face-to-face with skeptics, atheists, and hurting souls. Here are the five most common hard questions new believers face, answered directly from the King James Scriptures:

Q1: “If God is all-loving and all-powerful, why is there so much suffering, pain, and evil in the world?”

- ✦ **The KJV Answer:** God did not create a broken world. God created a perfect world, but human rebellion introduced sin, sickness, and curse into creation (Genesis 3, Romans 5:12). God did not remain distant from our pain; in Jesus Christ, God entered human suffering! On the cross, Jesus bore our griefs and carried our sorrows (Isaiah 53:4). One day soon, King Jesus will return to destroy evil forever and “*wipe away all tears from their eyes; and there shall be no more death, neither sorrow, nor crying, neither shall there be any more pain*” (Revelation 21:4).

Q2: “Why does God feel silent when I pray? Why didn’t He grant my specific request?”

- ✦ **The KJV Answer:** God is your loving Father, not a cosmic vending machine. God answers every sincere prayer in one of three ways:
- ✦ **Yes:** Direct grant when aligned with His will (1 John 5:14).
- ✦ **No:** Loving protection from something that would harm your soul long-term (James 4:3).
- ✦ **Wait:** Spiritual maturing process to build patience and faith (Romans 8:28, Psalm 27:14).

Never confuse God’s *silence* with His *absence*. The Lord is close to the brokenhearted (Psalm 34:18), and His delays are always appointments of grace!

Q3: “My old friends are mocking me or pulling away since I surrendered to Jesus. How do I handle this isolation?”

- ✦ **The KJV Answer:** When you step out of darkness into the light, old companions who love darkness will feel uncomfortable around your new lifestyle (1 Peter 4:4). Light and darkness cannot walk in seamless agreement (2 Corinthians 6:14). But Jesus gave an unshakeable promise:

“*Verily I say unto you, There is no man that hath left house, or brethren, or sisters, or father, or mother, or wife, or children, or lands, for my sake, and the gospel’s, But he shall receive an hundredfold now in this time, houses, and brethren, and sisters...*” — Mark 10:29-30 (KJV)

You may lose old worldly drinking buddies, but you gain an eternal family of spiritual brothers, sisters, and mentors in the Household of God!

Q4: “What if old temptations drag me down or I slip back into sin?”

- ✦ **The KJV Answer:** Learn to distinguish between **Satan’s Accusation** and the **Holy Spirit’s Conviction**:
- ✦ *Satan’s Accusation* says: “You failed! You are a hypocrite! You can never be saved!” It drives you into despair and isolation.
- ✦ *The Holy Spirit’s Conviction* says: “Child, that sin is beneath your royal identity in Christ. Rise up, confess it, and be cleansed!” (1 John 1:9).

Remember: There is no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus (Romans 8:1). If you stumble, don’t stay down—run to your High Priest for grace!

Q5: “Is it a sin to have intellectual doubts about the Bible or my faith?”

- ♦ **The KJV Answer:** Honest doubt is not unbelief. Unbelief is a stubborn refusal to submit to truth; doubt is a seeking heart looking for solid ground. When John the Baptist was sitting in Herod’s prison, he experienced a moment of doubt and sent messengers to ask Jesus: “*Art thou he that should come, or do we look for another?*” (Matthew 11:3). Jesus did not rebuke John; He sent back empirical proof of His miracles and messianic fulfillment! Bring your doubts to KJV Scripture and walk with mature spiritual leaders.

“Let’s Get Real”: Establishing Your Discipleship Mentorship

To grow into an unshakeable Kingdom leader, you cannot walk alone. Every growing believer needs three strategic relationships in their spiritual life:

Reflection & Deepening Questions

1. **James 1:5:** How does knowing that God *giveth liberally and upbraideth not* encourage you to bring your rawest questions to Him in prayer?
2. **Handling Isolation:** Look at Mark 10:29-30. Have you experienced any friction with old friends since following Christ, and how can your new church family fill that gap?
3. **The 3 Relationships:** Who is currently your “Paul” (spiritual mentor), and who is your “Barnabas” (godly peer friend)?

Action Step & Commissioning Prayer

- ♦ **Practical Action Step:** Identify the single biggest question or doubt currently troubling your mind. Write it down, open your KJV Bible, and schedule a 30-minute coffee meeting with your pastor, small group leader, or spiritual mentor to discuss it.
- ♦ **Commissioning Prayer:**

“Father of Light and God of all Wisdom, thank You for welcoming my seeking mind and answering my deepest questions. Give me an unshakeable mind anchored in Your Holy Scriptures. Help me stand bold as a prophet, priest, and king, ready always to give an answer to every man that asketh a reason of the hope that is in me. In Jesus’ victorious Name, Amen.”

CHAPTER 9: WHERE WE'RE GOING: CHURCH VISION & FUTURE PLANS

"Where there is no vision, the people perish: but he that keepeth the law, happy is he." — Proverbs 29:18 (KJV)

The Power of Prophetic Vision

Imagine a ship filled with able-bodied sailors, supplied with provisions, and powered by massive engines —yet floating in the middle of the harbor with no destination chart, no rudder setting, and no compass heading. Despite all its potential energy, that ship will drift aimlessly, burn fuel, rust in salt water, and eventually founder on the rocks.

In Proverbs 29:18, the King James Version states a profound law of human and spiritual destiny: *"Where there is no vision, the people perish."*

The Hebrew word for *vision* is **chazown**, meaning a divine revelation or prophetic sight imparted by God. And the word for *perish* is **parah**, which means to cast off restraint, drift aimlessly, and disintegrate into confusion.

Without a clear, God-given vision:

- ✦ Individuals drift into spiritual lukewarmness and apathy.
- ✦ Families break apart under cultural pressure.
- ✦ Churches turn inward, devolving into maintenance clubs arguing over minor preferences instead of conquering territory for King Jesus!

Vision is the spiritual rudder that directs our energy, dictates our priorities, and unleashes holy passion. In Habakkuk 2:2, the Lord commands: *"Write the vision, and make it plain upon tables, that he may run that readeth it."*

Vision Transforms Destinies: Lessons from the Jail Cell

As a jail chaplain ministering in Seminole County and Orange County Jail, I observe a stark pattern among released inmates.

When a man steps out of correctional gates with *no vision* for his future, he almost always gravitates back to old street corners, bad companions, and criminal habits. Within 90 days, he is back behind bars.

But when a prisoner surrenders to Jesus Christ and catches a **prophetic vision** for his life—seeing himself as a redeemed son of God, a faithful husband, a hardworking provider, and a soul-winner—everything changes! He steps out of jail with a purpose. He finds a local church family, gets a job, serves in ministry, and walks in victorious freedom.

If vision can transform a former convict into a Kingdom leader, imagine what God’s vision will do in your life!

The Three Pillars of Our Church Vision

As a new believer walking in your royal identity as a prophet, priest, and king, you are not called to be a spectator watching from the sidelines. You are part of an advancing Kingdom movement built upon three strategic pillars:

Pillar 1: Reaching the Lost (Evangelism & Local Compassion)

“For the Son of man is come to seek and to save that which was lost.” — Luke 19:10 (KJV)

Our primary mission is to break out of church walls and carry the light of Christ into dark places—prison cells, inner cities, nursing homes, college campuses, and local neighborhoods. We do not wait for the world to come to church; we take the Church to the world!

Pillar 2: Building Believers (Intentional Discipleship)

“Whom we preach, warning every man, and teaching every man in all wisdom; that we may present every man perfect in Christ Jesus.” — Colossians 1:28 (KJV)

Winning a soul to Christ is only the beginning. Our second pillar is to disciple every new believer through systematic Bible teaching (KJV), spiritual habit building, and small group community so you grow from a spiritual infant into an unshakeable leader.

Pillar 3: Sending Kingdom Ambassadors (Deployment & Global Missions)

“Now then we are ambassadors for Christ, as though God did beseech you by us...” — 2 Corinthians 5:20 (KJV)

We do not measure a church’s success merely by its *seating capacity*, but by its *sending capacity*! Our ultimate goal is to equip, commission, and deploy you as a royal ambassador into your workplace, civic leadership, church planting, and global mission fields.

“Let’s Get Real”: How Do My Personal Gifts Fit Into the Big Picture?

You might ask: *“I’m just a new believer. How can my small life contribute to this grand vision?”*

Think of a massive architectural blueprint for a cathedral. It requires master architects, stone masons, carpenters, electricians, glass artisans, and landscapers. If even one team fails to install their piece, the building remains incomplete.

In 1 Corinthians 12:18, Scripture declares: *“But now hath God set the members every one of them in the body, as it hath pleased him.”*

Whether your gift is welcoming guests at the door, operating audio/visual equipment, praying in secret, teaching children, or serving in prison outreach—**your piece of the puzzle is vital!** When you align your personal gifts with the church’s vision, your life takes on eternal significance.

Reflection & Deepening Questions

1. **Prophetic Vision:** How does catching a clear Kingdom vision for your life protect you from drifting into spiritual apathy or worldly distractions?
2. **The 3 Pillars:** Which of the three vision pillars (Reaching the Lost, Building Believers, Sending Ambassadors) fires up your passion the most?
3. **Your Role in the Body:** Read 1 Corinthians 12:18. How does knowing that God personally placed you in this church family change your sense of purpose?

Action Step & Commissioning Prayer

- ✦ **Practical Action Step:** Spend 20 minutes this week praying over the three vision pillars. Identify **one specific ministry area** in your church (e.g., greeting team, prayer team, youth ministry, local outreach, tech team) where you can plug in and serve over the next 90 days.
- ✦ **Commissioning Prayer:**

“Lord God of Hosts, thank You for giving our church family a clear, powerful, prophetic vision! I reject spiritual apathy and surrender my life to Your Great Commission. Align my personal heart with Your Kingdom vision. Use my gifts, my voice, and my story as a prophet, priest, and king to reach the lost, build believers, and expand Your glory in the earth. In Jesus’ mighty Name, Amen.”

CHAPTER 10: BECOMING A MEMBER: COVENANT & COMMITMENT

“Now ye are the body of Christ, and members in particular.” — 1 Corinthians 12:27 (KJV)

“Dating” the Church vs. Covenant Marriage

Imagine a man who has been “dating” a woman for ten years. He shows up when it’s convenient, enjoys her home-cooked meals, expects her affection, but the moment she faces sickness, financial strain, or hard times, he slips out the back door. He refuses to buy a ring, sign a marriage license, or make a public covenant vow. What would you call such a man? You would call him immature, self-centered, and untrustworthy!

Yet, millions of modern Christians treat the local church the exact same way!

They “date” the church for years. They consume the free coffee, enjoy the worship music, demand pastoral care during personal crises, but refuse to make a public covenant commitment. The moment a sermon challenges their comfort, a volunteer makes a mistake, or a financial need arises, they jump into their car and hunt for the next church in town.

In your royal identity as a prophet, priest, and king, God does not call you to be a perpetual consumer “dating” His house. **God calls you into Covenant Membership!**

Severed Organs vs. Attached Body Parts: A KJV Word Study

In 1 Corinthians 12:27, the Apostle Paul writes: *“Now ye are the body of Christ, and members in particular.”* Look at that phrase: **“members in particular”** (*melos ek merous*). In Greek, a *melos* is a physical limb or vital organ of a human body—an eye, a hand, a foot, or an ear.

Consider a human hand. As long as that hand is organically connected to your arm, life-giving blood flows through its veins, nerves carry signals from the brain, and the hand can build, heal, write, and fight. Now, imagine cutting that hand off and laying it on a table. Can a severed hand function? No! Within minutes, it turns cold, loses its strength, and decays.

A Christian who refuses to join and commit to a local church family is like a **severed hand** sitting on a table! You cannot survive on virtual live streams or isolated solo Christianity. You need the blood flow, protection, and accountability of the local Body of Christ to remain spiritually alive and fruitful.

The Four Pillars of the Membership Covenant

When you step forward to become a covenant member of your local church, you take up four royal vows of protection, responsibility, service, and testimony:

Commitment 1: Protecting the Unity of My Church

“Endeavouring to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace.” — Ephesians 4:3 (KJV)

Disunity and gossip are spiritual poison. As a covenant member, you vow to refuse gossip, silence divisive chatter, love your brothers and sisters, and follow biblical conflict resolution (Matthew 18:15).

Commitment 2: Sharing the Responsibility of My Church

“We give thanks to God always for you all, making mention of you in our prayers...” — 1 Thessalonians 1:2 (KJV)

You pledge to pray regularly for your pastors and leaders, attend corporate worship faithfully every week (Hebrews 10:25), and warmly welcome guests and new believers into the family.

Commitment 3: Serving the Ministry of My Church

“As every man hath received the gift, even so minister the same one to another, as good stewards of the manifold grace of God.” — 1 Peter 4:10 (KJV)

You discover your God-given spiritual gifts, roll up your sleeves, and actively serve in a ministry team (kids, greeting, tech, prison outreach, prayer) to build up the house of God.

Commitment 4: Supporting the Testimony of My Church

“Only let your conversation be as it becometh the gospel of Christ...” — Philippians 1:27 (KJV)

You pledge to live a holy, high-integrity lifestyle in your home, workplace, and community so that the Name of King Jesus is never dishonored by hypocrisy or scandal.

The Official Church Membership Covenant Pledge

“Let’s Get Real”: What If I Experience Disagreements or Offense in Church?

A major reason people run from membership is fear of conflict or past church hurt.

In any healthy family, siblings occasionally disagree! The mark of spiritual maturity is not the total absence of disagreement, but **how you handle conflict when it arises**:

- ✦ **Rule 1: Never Go Public or Go Online:** Do not post church complaints on social media or gossip in parking lots.
- ✦ **Rule 2: Go Directly to the Person in Private:** Follow Matthew 18:15—go privately to your brother or pastor with a humble, loving heart to seek reconciliation.
- ✦ **Rule 3: Cover Offenses with Grace:** *“The discretion of a man deferreth his anger; and it is his glory to pass over a transgression”* (Proverbs 19:11).

Reflection & Deepening Questions

1. **Dating vs. Marriage:** How does comparing church membership to marriage help you understand the importance of making a formal, public covenant commitment?
2. **The Severed Limb:** Read 1 Corinthians 12:27. What spiritual dangers face a believer who remains disconnected from a local church body?
3. **Protecting Unity:** Look at Ephesians 4:3. What practical steps will you take to ensure you never engage in or listen to church gossip?

Action Step & Commissioning Prayer

- ✦ **Practical Action Step:** Contact your church leadership this week and request to join the next **Membership Class / Covenant Service**. Read through the Membership Covenant Pledge above, sign your name in prayer, and prepare to stand with your spiritual family!
- ✦ **Commissioning Prayer:**

“Lord Jesus, Head of the Body, thank You for adopting me into Your eternal family and placing me in this local church. Today I step out of non-commitment and pledge my heart to this body. I promise to protect our unity, share our responsibility, serve with my gifts, and honor Your Name with a holy life. Use me to build Your house and advance Your Kingdom! In Jesus’ glorious Name, Amen.”

CHAPTER 11: GENEROSITY & STEWARDSHIP

“Every man according as he purposeth in his heart, so let him give; not grudgingly, or of necessity: for God loveth a cheerful giver.” — 2 Corinthians 9:7 (KJV)

The Open Hand vs. The Clenched Fist

Imagine two men standing in a downpour of rain:

- ✦ The first man holds his hands **clenched into tight fists**. He is so terrified of losing the few drops he holds that his knuckles turn white. But because his hands are tightly closed, he cannot receive any fresh water pouring from above!
- ✦ The second man holds his hands **wide open**. The rain fills his palms, and as he freely shares water with those standing around him, fresh rain continuously refills his hands.

In the spiritual realm, money and material resources operate under this exact law.

A person with a **clenched fist** lives in a prison of fear, greed, and scarcity. But a Kingdom believer who lives with an **open hand** understands a fundamental truth: **You are not an owner; you are a royal manager!**

“The earth is the LORD’S, and the fulness thereof; the world, and they that dwell therein.” — Psalm 24:1 (KJV)

God owns 100% of everything in existence—your bank account, your home, your lungs, your time, and your talents. When you give to God, you are not losing resources; you are returning a portion to the King who entrusted it to your care!

The Four Pillars of Kingdom Stewardship (The 4 T’s)

In your royal identity as a prophet, priest, and king, God has appointed you as a trustee over four sacred currencies:

A. Stewardship of Treasure (Finances & Tithes)

“Honor the LORD with thy substance, and with the firstfruits of all thine increase: So shall thy barns be filled with plenty...” — Proverbs 3:9-10 (KJV)

Scripture teaches two levels of financial giving:

1. **The Tithe (*Firstfruits*)**: The first 10% of your income brought to the local church storehouse (Malachi 3:10). The tithe is holy unto the Lord—it acknowledges God as your Provider before you pay any other bill!
2. **Offerings (*Freewill Gifts*)**: Over-and-above giving directed toward special ministry needs, prison outreach, global missions, and helping the poor.

B. Stewardship of Time

“Redeeming the time, because the days are evil.” — Ephesians 5:16 (KJV)

Every human being receives the exact same 168 hours each week. Time is a non-renewable currency. A royal manager does not waste time on mindless worldly distractions; you invest time in prayer, Scripture study, church gathering, and serving your family.

C. Stewardship of Talent (Skills & Gifts)

“As every man hath received the gift, even so minister the same one to another...” — 1 Peter 4:10 (KJV)

Whether God blessed you with organizational skills, musical ability, carpentry, teaching talent, or financial acumen, your talents were not given for self-aggrandizement. They were given to build up the Kingdom of God!

D. Stewardship of Testimony (Your Gospel Story)

“And they overcame him by the blood of the Lamb, and by the word of their testimony...” — Revelation 12:11 (KJV)

Your story of how Jesus saved you from sin and transformed your life is a high-value Kingdom asset! Don't bury your testimony; share it boldly to pull others out of darkness.

Cheerful Giving (*Hilaros*) and the Law of the Harvest

In 2 Corinthians 9:7, Paul writes that *“God loveth a cheerful giver.”*

The Greek word used for *cheerful* is **hilaros** (from which we derive our English word *hilarious*!).

God does not want you giving out of guilt, arm-twisting pressure, or reluctant obligation. He desires you to give with overflowing, joyful, hilarious delight—knowing that every dollar given into Kingdom soil is an investment in eternal souls!

“But this I say, He which soweth sparingly shall reap also sparingly; and he which soweth bountifully shall reap also bountifully.” — 2 Corinthians 9:6 (KJV)

Through my work with Gideons International, placing Bibles in schools, hotels, and prisons, and through our jail chaplaincy ministry in Seminole County and Orange County Jails, I have seen how faithful giving from ordinary believers funds free Scriptures and discipleship books that pull men back from the brink of suicide and crime. Your generosity has eternal compound interest!

Supporting Discipleship & Digital Ministry Outreach

Our ministry is committed to providing **free physical and digital discipleship books, workbooks, and study guides** to prison chaplains, inner-city ministries, and overseas mission churches who cannot afford them.

If this book has blessed your walk with Christ, you can partner with us to keep this mission expanding through simple, transparent giving channels:

- ✦  **Zelle (Zero Fee Instant Giving):** Send to thomasperdana@gmail.com (*Memo: Discipleship Ministry*)
- ✦  **PayPal (Online & Card Giving):** Direct Link or thomasperdana@gmail.com
- ✦  **Scannable QR Codes:** Use the QR Code page in the back Appendix of this book for instant phone scan giving!

“Let’s Get Real”: What If I Am Struggling Financially Right Now?

A question many new believers ask is: *“My budget is extremely tight right now. Can I afford to tithe or give?”*

Consider Mark 12:41-44. Jesus sat near the temple treasury and watched wealthy people toss in large sums. Then a poor widow stepped up and dropped in two small copper mites—worth less than a penny. Jesus called His disciples and declared: *“This poor widow hath cast more in, than all they which have cast into the treasury!”*

God does not measure the *size* of your gift; He measures the *sacrifice* of your heart! If you are in a tight season, start right where you are. Honor God with your first-fruits, trust Him as your Provider, and watch Him open the windows of Heaven over your life (Malachi 3:10)!

Reflection & Deepening Questions

1. **Manager vs. Owner:** How does knowing that God owns 100% of your resources (Psalm 24:1) relieve the anxiety of financial management?
2. **The 4 T's:** Which of the four areas of stewardship (Treasure, Time, Talent, Testimony) requires the most alignment in your life right now?
3. **Hilarious Giving:** What is the difference between giving grudgingly out of guilt vs. giving cheerfully (*hilaros*) out of gratitude?

Action Step & Commissioning Prayer

✦ **Practical Action Step:** On your very next paycheck or income source, practice **First-Fruits Stewardship**. Before paying any bill or buying groceries, set aside your 10% tithe for your local church and an offering for Kingdom outreach.

✦ **Commissioning Prayer:**

“Lord God of All Creation, I acknowledge that the earth is Yours and everything in it! Thank You for appointing me as a royal manager of Your resources. Give me an open hand, a generous heart, and a cheerful spirit. I dedicate my Treasure, Time, Talent, and Testimony to the expansion of Your Kingdom. Open the windows of Heaven over my life, and let my generosity bring glory to Your Name. In Jesus’ victorious Name, Amen.”

CHAPTER 12: YOUR NEXT STEP: READY TO GROW

“But grow in grace, and in the knowledge of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ. To him be glory both now and for ever. Amen.” — 2 Peter 3:18 (KJV)

From Commencement to Continual Growth

When a student walks across the stage at a university graduation, the ceremony is called a **commencement**. In English, *commence* does not mean to finish; it means to **begin**! The diploma is not a license to stop learning; it is a commission to step out into the world and apply what you have learned.

Completing this first book, *BELONG*, is your spiritual commencement ceremony!

When you opened Chapter 1, you may have carried feelings of isolation, spiritual doubt, or uncertainty about where you fit in God’s household. But over these 12 chapters, the living Word of God (KJV) has established your foundation:

- ✦ You know that you are **no longer a stranger or foreigner, but a fellowcitizen and a household member** (Ephesians 2:19).
- ✦ You are clothed in your royal identity as a **prophet, priest, and king** in Christ.
- ✦ You hold fast to the **four pillars of sound doctrine** (2 Timothy 1:13).
- ✦ You know how to operate in **biblical order** (1 Corinthians 14:40) and participate in **Water Baptism and Communion**.
- ✦ You have stepped out of consumerism into **Covenant Membership and Kingdom Stewardship**.

You belong at the Father’s table. But God loves you too much to let you remain a spiritual infant sitting in a high chair!

The Command to Grow: Milk to Solid Meat

“For when for the time ye ought to be teachers, ye have need that one teach you again which be the first principles of the oracles of God; and are become such as have need of milk, and not of strong meat. For every one that useth milk is unskilful in the word of righteousness: for he is a baby.” — Hebrews 5:12-13 (KJV)

In 2 Peter 3:18, the Apostle Peter issues an imperative command: “**grow in grace, and in the knowledge of our Lord...**”

The Greek verb Peter uses for *grow* is **auxanete**, which is in the present continuous tense. It means to keep on growing, expanding, and maturing every single day.

In physical life, if a human baby stayed in a crib drinking milk for fifteen years without growing, the parents would be heartbroken. In the spiritual realm, God desires you to move from **spiritual milk** (*to gala*) to **solid spiritual meat** (*sterea trophe*)!

As a jail chaplain in Seminole County and Orange County Jail, some of my greatest joys come from watching men who entered correctional pods as spiritually broken infants. They read their KJV Bibles, complete Book 1 (*BELONG*), and then step forward to become discipleship leaders in their jail pods—discipling other inmates and leading daily prayer circles!

Your 3-Book Discipleship Roadmap

Here is the grand 3-stage roadmap designed to take you from a new believer to an empowered Kingdom leader:

Official Book 1 Graduation Certificate & Charge

“Let’s Get Real”: How Do I Transition into Book 2 (GROW)?

To step directly into your next level of growth:

1. **Secure Your Copy of Book 2 (GROW):** Obtain *Book 2: GROW (Building Habits & Discovering Your S.H.A.P.E.)*.
2. **Download the S.H.A.P.E. PDF Worksheets:** Prepare your personal Spiritual Gifts, Heart, Abilities, Personality, and Experiences inventory worksheets.
3. **Walk with a Growth Partner:** Invite a Christian brother or sister, mentor, or small group to go through Book 2 together.

Reflection & Deepening Questions

1. **Spiritual Commencement:** Why is completing Book 1 considered your spiritual *commencement* (beginning) rather than a final stopping point?
2. **Milk to Meat:** Look at Hebrews 5:12-13. What steps will you take in your personal Bible study to move from spiritual milk to solid spiritual meat?
3. **Next Horizon:** How does knowing your unique **S.H.A.P.E.** in Book 2 excite you about finding your exact ministry fit in God’s house?

Action Step & Final Commissioning Prayer

✦ **Practical Action Step:** Open **Book 2 (GROW)**, read Chapter 1 today, and schedule your daily 15-minute quiet time spot for the upcoming week.

✦ **Final Commissioning Prayer:**

“Heavenly Father, Lord of Heaven and Earth, thank You for bringing me safely through Book 1 (BELONG)! Thank You that I am no longer an outsider or a stranger, but a cherished child in Your household, clothed in my royal identity as a prophet, priest, and king. I declare today that I am ready to GROW! Root me deep in Your Word, teach me the habits of spiritual maturity, and lead me by Your Spirit into Book 2. In the glorious, victorious Name of Jesus Christ, Amen!”



APPENDIX: ABOUT THE AUTHOR & MINISTRY VISION



ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Thomas Perdana (is a 59-year-old third-generation Chinese-Indonesian believer who surrendered his life to Jesus Christ at age 12. Walking with the Lord for over 47 years, his heart’s passion is to disciple believers, equip Kingdom leaders, and anchor new Christians in the unshakeable truth of God’s Word.

Thomas serves actively as a volunteer jail chaplain with **Good News Global** at the Seminole County Correctional Facility (and with **Orange County Jail Ministry** in Florida (bringing the transformational hope of the Gospel behind correctional bars. He also serves as Vice President of **The Gideons International** (North Seminole County Chapter, Florida) (dedicating his life to placing God’s Holy Word into hands across the globe.

Thomas and his family are active covenant members of **Westview Baptist Church** (in Sanford, Florida. Thank you for reading *The Discipleship Journey*! We invite you to partner with our discipleship ministry to help provide free books, study guides, and courses for seeking souls, prison chaplains, and overseas churches.



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